Congress general secretary, entrusted with the task of reviving the Congress in the key state of Uttar Pradesh. Singh was an old-style Congressman—a firm believer in social engineering and in a vision of secular politics that gave the minorities a special status. He was strongly anti-RSS, but was also deeply religious and ritualistic; a proud Thakur who flaunted his Hindu identity but routinely attacked ‘communal’ forces; a public-school alumnus from Daly College, Indore, who was just as comfortable in a five-star hotel as he was in a village panchayat. As Madhya Pradesh chief minister, he had built a strong equation with NGO groups and was seen to occupy the ‘secular’ space within the Congress once occupied by his political guru and another former Madhya Pradesh chief minister, Arjun Singh.

Rahul turned to him because he needed a strong political ‘face’ from the Hindi heartland to guide him through the maze of caste and community politics. For Singh, proximity to Rahul became the source of an independent power base at a time when his political career was staring at a dark tunnel. He promised to ‘deliver’ UP—the key prize that had eluded the Congress for two decades—to Rahul. The strategy was premised on reconstructing the Congress’s traditional electoral alliance—upper castes, Muslims and Dalits.

Singh took up the case of Muslim youth arrested in terror cases, questioning the role of the police in the 2008 Batla House encounter in Delhi, in which two suspected terrorists and a senior police officer were killed. The accused were from Azamgarh in UP, and Singh promised to deliver justice to them. He targeted the Sangh Parivar, accusing them of promoting ‘saffron terror’. He also reached out through a back channel to Hindu and Muslim religious leaders in an effort to break the Ayodhya deadlock.

This was politics from an earlier era—of vote banks, appeasement and allurements. Only that the space Singh was attempting to recapture was already firmly with parties like the BSP and SP. The politics of north India had changed, perhaps irreversibly, with the political rise of OBC and Dalit politicians through the 1980s and 1990s. Singh, though, remained confident that his strategy was working. On the eve of the 2012 UP elections, he had a